

EG India: Youth discontent remains major political threat for BJP as protests subside

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India

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Youth discontent remains major political threat for BJP as protests subside

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

* Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government has contained six weeks of student protests by sacrificing its education minister, but the underlying political vulnerability of youth unemployment remains, with nearly 30% of college graduates out of work.

* Despite the rare political setback for Modi, his government will be able to advance key aspects of its legislative agenda in the coming weeks, including planned constitutional changes intended to solidify the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP's) electoral advantage.

* Youth dissatisfaction is poised to come back into focus in several state elections next year, especially in the country's most populous state, Uttar Pradesh.

Concession to student protesters is a rare political loss for Modi. On 6 June, a social media-inspired movement called the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) began a protest demanding Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over irregularities in medical examinations. Although modest at first, the protests began to mobilize tens of thousands of youth in New Delhi by 19 July, with demonstrations spreading to other urban centers (see: Modi government likely to reach compromise with student-led protesters , 24 July 2025).

The government's initial hopes that the movement would fizzle out proved misplaced. With its legislative agenda stalled, it opted to sacrifice a single minister. Though the protests did not boost the opposition, this was a major loss of face for Modi. In over 12 years in power, he has given in to protesters' demands only three times before. It was also one of the few times the government failed to dominate the public narrative.

Opposition will fail to capitalize on unrest, allowing Modi to resume legislative agenda. The government will seek to restore a business-as-usual ambiance as quickly as possible amid some disruptions to the current monsoon session in parliament (which runs through 13 August) as the opposition tries to exploit the government's defeat. However, with the protest venues already empty and the CJP insisting it is apolitical, the opposition strategy is unlikely to have legs. The protests will have no significant impact on Modi's ability to push through his legislative agenda and have prompted no internal pushback within the BJP or from coalition partners.

In the present monsoon session, the government is expected to pass a handful of economic overhauls. These include bills to assist small and medium enterprises and to exempt foreign investors from paying income tax on interest earnings and capital gains tax on government securities.

Constitutional majority for redrawing parliamentary constituencies is in sight. This is the BJP's highest legislative priority this year, with the party aiming to reduce the percentage of seats from the opposition-dominated southern states and increase those in its northern strongholds while expanding urban representation (see: Modi trades legislative loss on women's parliamentary quotas for electoral gain , 22 April 2026).

Imminent defections from the Trinamool Congress and the near-conclusion of negotiations with the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam are expected to deliver the government the two-thirds parliamentary support needed for the redraw legislation. The bill has a very strong chance of passage during the winter session that starts in December.

Unemployment will continue to drive youth discontent, though most are politically disengaged. The protests were a symptom of a much larger political problem for the Modi government: growing disaffection because of persistently high unemployment among educated youth. Official figures place joblessness among urban youth at 16.2% in June. International Labor Organization figures say 29.1% of college graduates are unemployed. A Gen Z Indian is six times more likely not to have a job than a Millennial. Structural changes to the economy, most notably the decline of major employers such as the IT services industry, have contributed to this sense of frustration.

In the 2019 national elections, Modi had a five- to seven-percentage-point lead among young voters compared to older demographics. This edge was lost in the 2024 elections and is probably much lower today. Surveys indicate only a quarter of young Indians have any partisan inclinations, but many of them have only known Modi as prime minister, so antiestablishment sentiment tends to focus on him. They are also the demographic that is most unhappy with the BJP's heavy-handed approach to civil society, the media, and censorship.

Youth disaffection is likely to have an impact on next year's state elections. Fortunately for the BJP, there are no state elections and almost no parliamentary byelections this calendar year. However, at least five state elections will be held in February-March next year. Four are BJP-led, including the country's most populous state, Uttar Pradesh. Even before the protests broke out, the BJP's internal polling showed strong anti-incumbency sentiment across these states.

The ripple effects of the student protests are now expected to add to the ruling party's political problems. Uttar Pradesh will be a particular challenge, as nearly 34% of eligible voters are in the 18-29 age bracket. It remains unclear whether the CJP movement gives birth to a new political party, throws its support behind an opposition party, or simply leads young voters to sit out the elections. While Modi's parliamentary majority will remain stable no matter the results, any major state losses next year could well initiate a debate over the post-Modi succession within the BJP.

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